

A PEOPLE WORKBOOK

Heart Over Head

Communicating with yourself and others
without making anyone wrong

A workbook on Internal Family Systems and Nonviolent Communication

No one is wrong. No winning, no losing. Just presence, and what is alive and true.

WELCOME

Why this matters

Most of the suffering in our relationships, including the one we have with ourselves, comes from one habit: judging from the head instead of listening from the heart.

When we judge, someone has to be wrong. A partner is "unfair." A friend is "flaky." Some part of us is "lazy" or "broken." Then we defend, attack, collapse or shut down, and nobody gets what they actually need.

This workbook teaches a different way. It draws on two bodies of work. Internal Family Systems (IFS) shows us that every part of us has a positive intention. Nonviolent Communication (NVC) shows us that every action, including the ones that hurt, is an attempt to meet a need.

Put together, they give you one practice you can use inward and outward: *see the need beneath the behavior, and respond to that.*

How to use this workbook

1. Read the foundation. Pages 3–5 give you the core ideas and a list of feelings and needs to refer back to.
2. Study the examples. Each one shows the same moment twice: once from the head, once from the heart.
3. Sit with the questions. Page 10 turns the examples into questions about your own life. Pick real situations that have been bothering you. The more honest the judgment, the more you'll get out of it.
4. Go slowly. This isn't about getting it right. It's about getting curious.

A NOTE

- Parts work can bring up old, tender things. If something heavy comes up, slow down and bring it to your coach or a therapist. You don't have to do it alone.

THE FOUNDATION

No one is wrong

Every part of us, and every person in front of us, is trying to meet a need. Judgment ("they're wrong," "I'm bad") comes from the head. Presence and curiosity come from the heart. There's no winning or losing here, only what is alive and what is true.

When we listen from the heart, we can feel what is alive in someone. We can empathize and help them meet their needs without making ourselves the problem. And we can stop blaming and shaming ourselves for how we've shown up, and open our hearts to the deeper intention underneath.

AFFECTED, NOT RESPONSIBLE

I can affect someone's unmet need without being responsible for it. That frees me to empathize without defending, collapsing or carrying blame.

The same goes inward: I can see how I showed up without shaming the part that did it.

100% RESPONSIBILITY

Taking 100% responsibility means owning my response: my words, my actions, my repair. It does not mean owning everyone else's feelings.

Responsibility is power. Blame and shame are just pain.

The shift

FROM THE HEAD	FROM THE HEART
Judges	Listens
Needs to win	Seeks to understand
Asks "who's wrong?"	Asks "what's alive here?"
Defends or attacks	Stays present
Takes it personally	Sees the need beneath it
Shames the part	Befriends the part

THE TWO LENSES

Parts and needs

Internal Family Systems

IFS, developed by Dr. Richard Schwartz, sees the mind as a family of parts, each with its own feelings, beliefs and job. No part is bad. Even the ones that cause trouble are trying to help.

Protectors keep us safe. Managers try to stay in control (the critic, the planner, the pusher). Firefighters rush in to stop pain fast (numbing, snapping, bingeing).

Exiles carry old hurt, shame or fear. Protectors work hard to keep them out of sight.

Self is who you are underneath all the parts. It's calm, curious and compassionate. It can't be damaged, only covered up.

Unblending is the move from "I am angry" to "a part of me is angry." That little bit of space lets Self lead.

Nonviolent Communication

NVC, developed by Marshall Rosenberg, holds that everything a person says or does is an attempt to meet a need. Judgments, criticism and blame are painful ways of expressing needs that aren't being met. NVC has four parts:

1. **Observation**
   What happened, without evaluation
2. **Feeling**
   What's alive in me or them
3. **Need**
   The universal need underneath
4. **Request**
   A clear, doable ask, not a demand

YOU KNOW SELF IS LEADING WHEN YOU FEEL THE 8 CS

Curiosity	Calm	Clarity	Compassion
Confidence	Courage	Creativity	Connectedness

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER

IFS gives you the map: who inside you is reacting, and what it's protecting. NVC gives you the language: how to name what's alive and ask for what's needed. Use both, inward and outward.

REFERENCE

Feelings & Needs

Come back to this page whenever you're stuck on what a part, or a person, is feeling or needing.

FEELINGS WHEN NEEDS ARE MET

Calm · peaceful · relieved · grateful · hopeful · tender · joyful · energized · curious · confident · connected · proud · moved · safe · content

FEELINGS WHEN NEEDS AREN'T MET

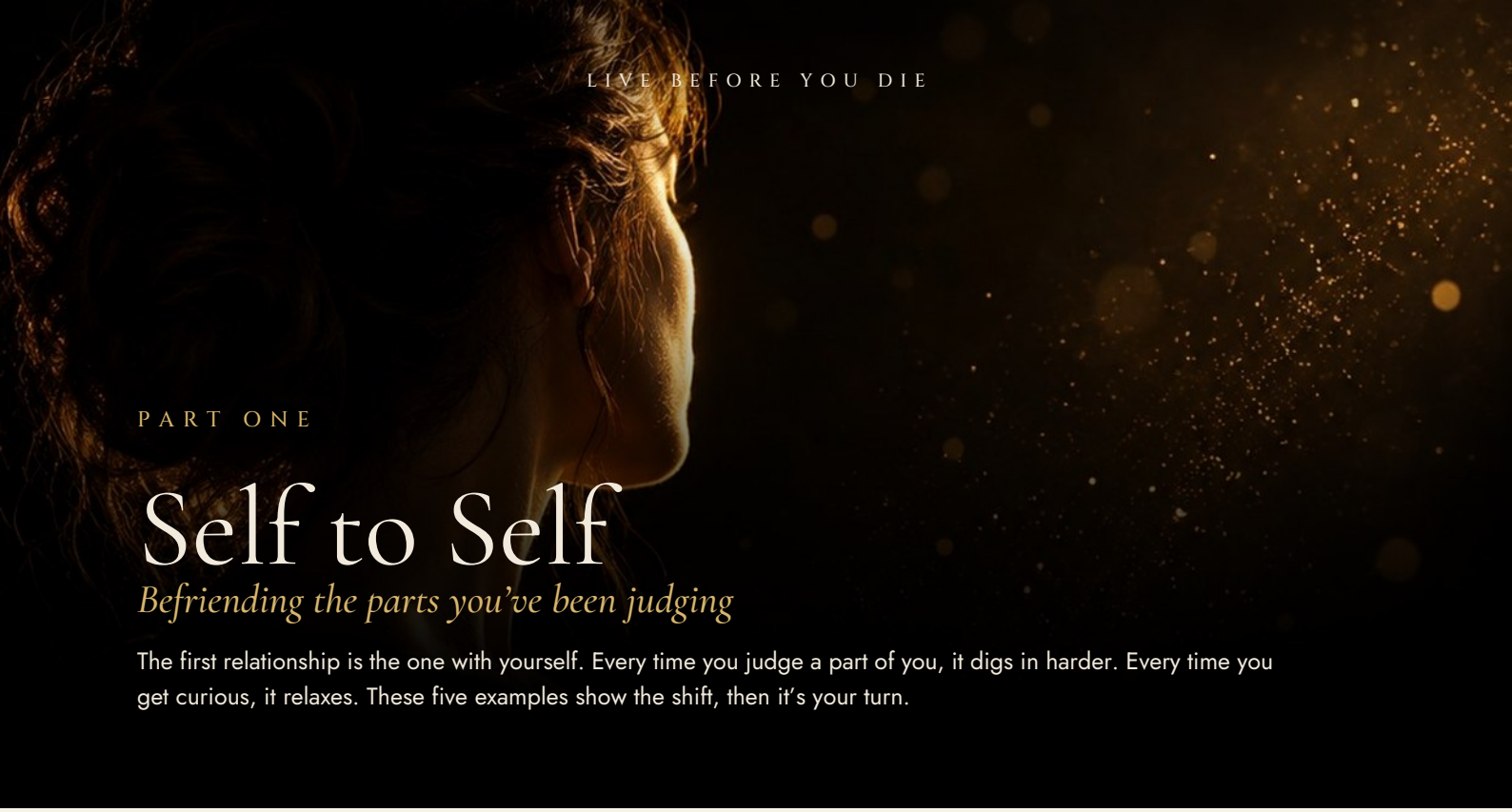
Tired · overwhelmed · anxious · afraid · hurt · lonely · frustrated · resentful · ashamed · embarrassed · disappointed · sad · confused · irritated · discouraged · numb · jealous · insecure

Universal needs

Connection	To be seen, heard, understood and valued. Belonging, closeness, acceptance, warmth, partnership
Safety	Security, stability, predictability, reassurance, trust, protection
Rest & ease	Rest, restoration, space, comfort, relief, play, simplicity
Autonomy	Choice, freedom, independence, space to decide for myself
Meaning	Purpose, contribution, growth, progress, competence, integrity, honesty
Respect	Recognition, appreciation, dignity, fairness, consideration

A HELPFUL TEST

A real need doesn't depend on any one person or action. "I need him to call me" is a strategy. "I need connection and reassurance" is the need underneath. Needs open up options; strategies box us in.



PART ONE

Self to Self

Befriending the parts you've been judging

The first relationship is the one with yourself. Every time you judge a part of you, it digs in harder. Every time you get curious, it relaxes. These five examples show the shift, then it's your turn.

EXAMPLE 1

Taking a day off

You take a day to rest, and by mid-afternoon the guilt kicks in.

FROM THE HEAD

"You're lazy. Real high performers don't rest. You just wasted a whole day."

FROM THE HEART

A depleted part is asking for restoration. A driven part is scared of falling behind. Both have good intentions, and both deserve to be heard.

NEEDS Rest · Restoration · Security

> *"I hear you, tired part. You've been carrying a lot. Of course you need rest. And driven part, I know you're worried we'll lose momentum. Rest is how we keep it."*

EXAMPLE 2

Procrastinating on something important

There's a launch, a hard conversation or a big call you know you need to make, and you keep finding reasons not to.

FROM THE HEAD

"What is wrong with me? I know exactly what to do and I'm not doing it."

FROM THE HEART

Procrastination is usually a protector. It may be guarding you against failure, rejection or being seen. It isn't lazy; it's afraid.

NEEDS Safety · Reassurance · Acceptance

> *"What are you protecting me from? What are you afraid would happen if I did this?" Then: "What would help you feel safe enough to let me take one small step?"*

EXAMPLE 3

Numbing at night

It's late, you're tired, and you've been scrolling (or drinking, or eating) for an hour you didn't plan on.

FROM THE HEAD

"No discipline. Same pattern again. Pathetic."

FROM THE HEART

A firefighter part is rushing in to soothe something painful: loneliness, stress, emptiness. It's trying to help, even if the way it helps costs you.

NEEDS Comfort · Relief · Ease

> *"Thank you for trying to help me feel better. What are you trying to soothe right now? Is there another way I can give you that?"*

EXAMPLE 4

Relating to the inner critic

You notice how hard you are on yourself, and then you criticize yourself for being so self-critical.

FROM THE HEAD

"I hate how hard I am on myself. I need to get rid of this voice." (Judging the judge.)

FROM THE HEART

The critic isn't the enemy. It usually wants to protect you from failure, embarrassment or not being enough. It needs to be acknowledged, and to learn it can trust you.

NEEDS Acknowledgment · Trust · Protection

> *"Critic, I see how hard you work to keep me from getting hurt. What are you afraid of? I've got this now. You can soften a little."*

EXAMPLE 5

After showing up poorly with someone

You snapped at your partner, your kids or your team, and now you can't stop replaying it.

FROM THE HEAD

"I'm a terrible partner, father, leader. I always ruin things." (The shame spiral.)

FROM THE HEART

Two parts are here. One was overwhelmed and needed space. The other feels ashamed because it deeply values being loving. Both deserve compassion. Accountability without shame is what makes real repair possible.

NEEDS Space · Integrity · Connection

> *"The part of me that snapped was overloaded. The part that feels bad cares so much about being kind. I can hold both, then go repair from a clean place."*



PART TWO

Self to Others

Listening for the need beneath the behavior

When someone's behavior lands on us, it's easy to make it about us, or to make them wrong. Listening from the heart lets us empathize, help where we can and stay out of blame. Affected, not responsible.

EXAMPLE 6

Your partner is upset when you come home

You walk in after a long day and your partner is already upset with you.

FROM THE HEAD

"I've been working all day for us and this is what I walk into? She's being unfair."

FROM THE HEART

She may be needing to be seen in how much she's carried, heard in her day, valued as a partner and connected after time apart. You may have affected this, but you aren't at fault for it.

NEEDS To be seen · Heard · Valued · Connection

> *"It sounds like today was a lot, and maybe you've been wanting more of me. Is that right? I want to hear it. Tell me."*

EXAMPLE 7

A team member misses a deadline

A project you were counting on didn't land when it was supposed to.

FROM THE HEAD

"Unreliable. I can't count on anyone. I'll just do it myself."

FROM THE HEART

They might be overwhelmed, unclear on priorities or afraid to ask for help. They may need clarity, support or capacity. Your need for reliability is real too, and it's valid.

NEEDS Theirs: Clarity · Support · Yours: Reliability

> *"I noticed the project didn't land on Friday. What got in the way? I need to be able to count on timelines, so let's figure out what would make that work for you."*

EXAMPLE 8

A parent criticizes your life choices

Your mother or father questions your business, where you live or the path you've chosen.

FROM THE HEAD

"They never support me. They'll never get it."

FROM THE HEART

Behind the criticism there is often fear and love. They may need reassurance that you're safe, and some connection with a life they don't understand.

NEEDS Reassurance · Security · Connection

> *"I'm hearing how much you worry about me. That comes from caring, and I appreciate it. Can I share what this path means to me?"*

EXAMPLE 9

A friend cancels at the last minute

Plans you were looking forward to fall through an hour before.

FROM THE HEAD

"Typical. I'm clearly not a priority."

FROM THE HEART

Their cancellation is about their needs, which might be rest, overwhelm or something they haven't said. It isn't a verdict on your worth. Your disappointment points to your own need for connection and reliability. Honor it without blaming them.

NEEDS Theirs: Rest · Ease · Yours: Connection · Reliability

> *"No worries, I hope you're okay. I'll be honest, I was really looking forward to it, so let's lock in another time soon."*

EXAMPLE 10

Someone gets defensive about your feedback

A client or colleague pushes back hard, or goes cold, after you share honest feedback.

FROM THE HEAD

"They're ungrateful and can't take feedback." Or the reverse: "I said it wrong. I've failed them."

FROM THE HEART

Defensiveness is a protector. They may feel exposed and need respect, safety or to feel capable. You can stay steady, because their reaction isn't something you have to fix or win.

NEEDS Respect · Safety · Competence

> *"It seems like that landed hard. That's not my intention. I believe in you. What did you hear me say? I want to make sure we're on the same page."*

PUT IT TO WORK

Your turn

Pick one real situation for each part. Answer in your head, in a journal or out loud with someone you trust. Go slowly. This isn't about getting it right. It's about getting curious.

SELF TO SELF

Pick something you've been judging yourself for: a habit, a mood, a mistake, a way you showed up. Then get curious about the part behind it.

1. What's been bothering me about myself
2. The judgment, in my exact words *Write it as harshly as it actually sounds.*
3. Which part is speaking? Which part is being judged?
4. What is the judged part feeling? What does it need? *Use the Feelings & Needs list on page 5.*
5. What is its deeper, positive intention? What is it trying to do for me?
6. What I want to say to it, from the heart
7. What it needs from me now *One small way I can help meet that need.*

SELF TO OTHERS

Pick a real situation with someone where you've made a judgment: a partner, a parent, a friend, a client, a team member. Slow it down and find the needs on both sides.

1. The person, and the situation
2. What happened *Just the observation, as a camera would record it. No evaluation.*
3. My judgment about them, in my exact words
4. How I may have affected this, and why I'm still not responsible for their needs
5. What they might be feeling and needing
6. What I'm feeling and needing
7. What I could say *An empathic reflection, plus an honest request.*

MAKE IT DAILY

Insight fades. Practice sticks. Take two minutes at the end of each day with these four questions.

1. Where did I judge myself or someone else today?
2. What was alive in me, or in them? What was the feeling?
3. What need was underneath it?
4. What would the heart say, or do, now?

Every judgment is a painful expression of an unmet need, including the judgments we have about ourselves. When we listen from the heart, there's no one left to blame. Only someone left to understand.



LIVE BEFORE YOU DIE

WHAT COMES NEXT

Ready to win at work and at home?

Live Before You Die helps driven founders win at work and at home. If this landed, here are two ways to keep going.

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01 Join the community

Build real relationships with founders who get it. Brett leads the personal side, Noah leads the business side.

JOIN THE COMMUNITY

www.skool.com/livebeforeyoudie/about

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02 Work with us one-on-one

With Brett: Deep coaching on purpose, connection and performance, including the 7-day experience.

BOOK A CALL WITH BRETT

calendly.com/brettroderickbailey/1-1-w-brett-60

With Noah: A Sales Leak Diagnostic and a done-for-you sales system, so the business stops running through you.

TALK TO NOAH

form.jotform.com/262762618270056

Free to share with anyone it might help.